NARRATIVE & SYSTEMS DESIGN PORTFOLIO

Kingdom of None

A turn-based roguelite card RPG in development · Godot 4



Tomás Becerra

Narrative & Systems Designer

ONLINE The interactive version: the 36 territories, the card engine, the systems

EMAIL tomas22becerra@gmail.com

BASED IN Rome · open to relocation in Europe

THE PREMISE

The stone that agrees with you

Four peoples share a continent, and under it runs a mineral called the Veth. Wear a ring set with it, look into a mirror and say: I look good today. You will feel that it is true.

The stone seems to agree with whoever holds it. It also carries heat, and under the right conditions it makes the wings of dead griffins fly. With those wings the Hilläru, the last people to arrive and the fewest in number, took the sky, and from the sky they took the continent: its tribute, its archives, its law. The same process, with a different measure of Veth, makes gunpowder. The stone that gave them their power also makes the weapon that can bring them down.

Everyone needs the Veth, and no two peoples agree on what it is. For the Orthal of the Father it is a voice that demands labour; for the Orthal of the Mother, a stone that does not speak. The Yrei hear in it a dialect of the sea. The Pherion guilds put it to work. The Hilläru treat it as engineering and decline to give it a theology. Each reading has its own politics, and every one of them is a reason to fight.

Even the world's own records describe the Veth in two vocabularies that cannot both be true. In one, it perceives, waits and chooses. In the other, it chooses nothing and only registers what the world was always able to become. If the stone that agrees with you has no will of its own, whose will has been moving the continent?

Kingdom of None does not answer. It is a game, and it asks the question where a game can: in the rules.

THIS DOCUMENT

The world 3

Voices of the continent 4

Event · The Cart That Whispers 5

Event · Fool's Quartz 6

Mission design · The Ring 7

Canon · The Jorrághar 8

Cards and items as writing 9

Four registers 10

The making 11

> The player in Kingdom of None does not direct the story and is not its hero. The story is told through the errands of people whose interests pull against each other; the player watches it from inside, and takes part. Everything in this document is written from that position.

Pages 5 and 6 are built and playable. Pages 7 and 8 are design in progress, and say so.



The continent map, as it appears in the game.

YEAR 722 AFTER THE REFOUNDATION

The world

The Yrei emerged from the sea. The Orthal were found by them, already living on the land. From their encounter came the Pherion, the sons of land and sea. The Hilläru came later, as a political apparatus.

Twelve provinces, three per people, thirty-six territories. Provinces open in three blocks, and a block opens only when the previous one is complete in all four peoples: progression runs across cultures before it runs deeper into one. Every province has a capital with a government and a loyalty, and the loyalties want different things from the order of the world.

Pherion

Valley guilds and old griffin houses. The guilds forge the continent from Ashford; the houses keep the griffin on their banners long after the Hilläru harvested the last one.

Crossfen · Thornval · Ashford

Orthal

Desert and mountain. The Father speaks from the rock through the Lectorate of Umbrakhad; the Mother of the desert teaches that stones do not speak.

Sûrath · Drakh'ul · Umbrakhad

Yrei

The oldest empire, broken by the Argument. The reef still trades in sea-Veth; the polar north forbids it; Thessunar has understood the most and said the least.

Oreya · Auvaelis · Thessunar

Hilläru

The last to arrive and the fewest. More a class than a race. They rule from floating islands and from an archive in Seld that decides what the world officially remembers.

Seld · Karathos · Veliornath

PROVINCE EPIGRAPHS

Someone always speaks

CROSSFEN

"Sorry, friend, but..." he said without stopping. "Crime is older than justice, and you should know it."

THORNVAL

The griffin myth tells of an eagle inseminating a horse. It is not particularly elaborate.

ASHFORD

"Lord Faldurs of the Council has sent another dove. He insists on knowing what we spend so much sulphur on." "Fireworks, for his next visit."

DRAKH'UL

The first foreign delegation to visit the Vertebrae asked about the cave paintings, and what they meant. The Orthal said they did not know: when they arrived, the paintings were already there.

UMBRAKHAD

They dug deep in search of something they did not know they were looking for, until they found it. The one who strayed claims the tradition has the order backwards.

THESSUNAR

"No one keeps more secrets than the sea, but perhaps the mountain has something to say."

AUVAELIS

The simplest and most honest truth is that the Óaedori were a complicated family.

SELD

"It is not enough to write history. It must also be defended. Lie when necessary. Silence the noise. Peace is quiet for a reason."

VELIORNATH

Nänn of Veliornath gave up everything for a poor woman and a humble life on the rivers. His father never forgave him.

SELD · THE PLAINS OF PHAENSELD

The wheat stretches as far as the eye can see. Hope does not reach that far.

UMBRAKHAD · THE FIFTH REGENT'S RIFT

Umbrakhad is governed; of that there is no doubt. The question is a different one.

ASHFORD · THE SEIGNORY

Everyone in Ashford knows what the word "gunpowder" means. Even so, no one would admit to knowing someone who knows an alchemist.

House rules for the text

- Two registers, never mixed. The game register is mechanical and instructive. The world register always speaks from inside the world, through someone.
- No narrator without an owner. Every line has a source: a person, a document, an inscription, a saying, a recipe. Who speaks matters.
- No second person in lore. No decorative adjectives. No moral that closes the fragment.
- The world never states its own ontology. Nobody says what the Veth is; they say the rock hums, the Father asks, the sea speaks.

Each province opens with an epigraph and each territory with a line, written in the voice of the people who live there. All thirty-six, with an in-game render of each, are in the interactive version.

CROSSFEN D1 · THREAD: THE TRAGEDY OF RORYS MERN

The Cart That Whispers

Thread premise: Rorys Mern, a young griffin knight and a hopeless romantic, is running to the desert with his lover, a noble. He killed a company of Griffin guards to get away, and there is a price on his head in Crossfen. The player does not know any of this yet.

A young foreigner pushes a covered cart along the ford path. His Pherion armour is too big for him; whoever wore it before was a grown man. Inside the cart there is a whisper, two voices, or one that answers itself. When their eyes meet, the whisper stops. The young man greets the traveller with more courtesy than the forest is used to.

Walk on.	"Every cart its own load." Nothing happens, and the world remembers that the cart was seen.
Help with the cart.	*The young man pushes hard for someone so thin, and always keeps himself between the canvas and the help. He thanks with a nod. The whisper does not return until the cart is far away.*
Read what is left unsaid. COSMOPOLITANISM 2	*The courtesy belongs to a high house; the accent, to the Helm. The armour keeps the shape of another body. And the whisper falls silent before strangers but does not struggle: whoever rides inside the cart rides of their own will.*

> The event never names Rorys. Only a body that can read a foreign court notices the house, the accent and the borrowed armour, and only that reading answers the question a player would ask first: is someone being held in there? Help is rewarded with the same picture seen from closer, not with information.

THE FOUR RULES OF RORYS

Writing this first event produced the rules that every event, situation and lore fragment in the game now follows.

1. **One-way connection.** An event reads the world (houses, provinces, factions), but the world never depends on the event having happened. That is what lets the game hold hundreds of events without becoming fragile.
2. **Conditions as a set.** A mission condition, such as knowing the name of a Brokerage boss, accepts several sources. Any one of them satisfies it; the rest are settled.
3. **The tome is reward and key.** A lore fragment pays its own experience when read, and records a fact that unlocks other content.
4. **Titled threads.** A named arc is the unit the journal tracks. The title is the structure. A thread crosses provinces and runs.



Greyleaf Forest, Crossfen D1 · in-game render of the run map

CROSSFEN D1 · THE FIRST LESSON ABOUT THE VETH

Fool's Quartz

On a blanket by the path, blue stones sorted by size. The pedlar calls them delta Veth, and lowers his voice to say it. The price is low.

Buy a stone.

"It promises a lot." Six gold. The bag receives *Celestial quartz: blue stone from the delta. Pretty, cold, mute. The pedlar wrapped the stone in dyed cloth and tied it with two turns of thread. He took the six coins without haggling.*

Let him sell.

"The forest has its trades." Behind, a muleteer paid the full price without looking at the stone twice. The pedlar pocketed the coin and called the next.

Listen to the stone. SKILL: ATTENTIVE LISTENING

The stone is silent. Dyed quartz from the delta. In the Igde, Veth is known by how it travels: with an escort, without a manifest, appraised twice before it touches water. What was on the blanket travelled alone.

Weigh it in the hand. VETH CONNECTION 2

In the hand, nothing: no old warmth, no pulse, none of that weight that is not weight. The pedlar held the gaze without hurry. At no point did he say what the stone did; he said what it was worth.



The Blue Dunes, Sûrath · concept art

> Four ways to meet a fake: pay, watch, use a skill, use a stat. The two that see through it grant the same piece of knowledge, how the Pherion recognise real Veth, which later content accepts as already known. The player who buys learns nothing in the moment; the item description already says *mute*, for whoever reads it.

LATER, IN ANOTHER PROVINCE

Celestial quartz, or "Fool's Veth", is a bright stone with hallucinogenic properties, famous among caravaners whose pockets are fuller than their heads. House Khêmur controls every smoking sanctuary in the region.

The territory line of the Blue Dunes, Sûrath D2. The player who bought the stone in Crossfen reads it hours, or runs, later, and understands what happened. The game never says it directly.

CROSSFEN AND AUVAELIS · TWO MISSIONS, EITHER ORDER IN DESIGN

The Ring

Crossfen, Old Edóvan. The daughter of Lord Roldor Dovan is found dead by the river, wearing a bright Veth ring. Keep the ring and the player gains the item. Return it to the family and the player gains their favour, and the story goes on, branching later. An immediate reward against the continuation of a story.

Oreya, Auvaelis, Crossfen. A Yrei woman from the polar north is looking for her son. Pän of the Ivories is a teenager who wanted to see the world. He stole a ring his father Yaxxat kept hidden, Veth, forbidden in the north since the Argument that broke the Yrei Empire, and sold it to Brokerage thugs in Auvael, swapping it at the last moment for a fake he had dyed himself. The thugs follow him to Ynx of the Birds. Yaxxat dies there: either executed for hiding the forbidden mineral, or killing the brokers to protect his son. Pän escapes south with the real ring, toward Old Edóvan.

Lord Roldor Dovan let Veth jewellery circulate freely through Edóvan so as not to have problems with the Brokerage. He has just lost the only thing that ever mattered to him, and he blames himself.

THE ITEM

"I love you, son."

Yaxxat of the Ivories, before he was executed.

Yaxxat probably never said it to Pän, and that may be the whole of Pän's rebellion: he wanted to be seen. The ring carries what the father kept silent, and it ends up on the wrong hand.



Éluar Imai, Auvaelis D2



The Dáiren Delta, Crossfen D2

THE DESIGN PROBLEM

The dead daughter is an early mission for a player who starts in Crossfen; the missing son, for a player who starts in Oreya. Neither can assume the other has been played.

The answer: write both to stand alone, and let whichever comes second rewrite the first. Starting in Crossfen, a stranger's dead daughter becomes, much later, the end of a northern family. Starting in Oreya, a runaway boy's story gets an ending the player recognises on a hand by a river. The rule of Rorys holds: the world never depends on either mission having happened.

Still open: how the ring passes from Pän to Dovan's daughter, and how the item's attribution ("before he was executed") reads in the branch where Yaxxat dies fighting.



The Plains of Phaenseld, Seld D2 · in-game render

THE GAP

Seld sits in the middle of the continent, on its most fertile plain. The canon said little about who lived there before the Hilläru founded their administrative capital: “dispersed communities of mixed lineage, too poor to interest any power”. A world this concerned with who owns history had left its own centre unclaimed.

SELD · BEFORE THE HILLÄRU IN DESIGN

The Jorrághar

A mixed, proto-Pherion lineage that split off from the first encounters between Orthal and Yrei and settled the plains of Seld before the Refoundation. Sedentary, peaceful and nearly defenceless, they lived on the edge between the desert, the Vertebrae and the valley while the Yrei Empire ruled. They took no side in the civil war, and when it ended they were gone.

Three versions, none final. The Hilläru founding story speaks of empty land with no prior claim. The third level of the Seld archive records communities absorbed as farm labour for Phaenseld. Popular memory speaks of the greatest extermination in the continent’s history. Some deny the Jorrághar ever existed as a people at all.

What survives. A name. A way of speaking: the common tongue as spoken in Seld has a lilt that sets it apart from every other speaker on the continent. And perhaps a governor. Jhoral Ghalan (working name) carries a surname found in Seld’s oldest registers of day labourers, and a first name that may come from the vanished people: *Jorr-*, from proto-Urkût *yûra*, “earth”, and *-aghari*, “of the”. Of those of the earth. He tells himself he is a good man, and he is partly right. The Hilläru court does not take him seriously.

> A people that became a class, ruled by a class that became a people. The Seld epigraph, “It is not enough to write history. It must also be defended”, now has a first victim.

Why it matters for play: the pacifist who took no side is a recurring question in Kingdom of None. The Jorrághar answer it the way the world answers most things, without a verdict: the thesis can be right and the world still unjust.

108 SIGNATURE MOVES · 6 IMPACT TYPES · 200+ CARDS

Rules text and a voice

Every card pairs the game register, which must be exact, with a line from the world, which must belong to someone. The line should sit close to the mechanic and tell a small story by implication.

Fair Bet (1)



Common · Wanderer · Crossfen

Pay 2 cycle. Draw a card. If it is an attack card, its first impact causes bleed and gets +2 damage. If it is a defence card, its first impact gains +3 block. Otherwise, discard it.

That's how it is.

In the Father's Name (3)



Elite · Okrosh · Drakh'ul

Requires 6 fury: instantly kill any target (bosses: at 20% HP or less).

"Give me back my cavalry, Stórde! You damned idiot!" Shouts in the Great Palace of Veliornath, 98 DR.

Grey Protocol (1)



Elite · Agent · Seld

Deal 4 damage to the target enemy. Removed after use.

"It's the law," he said, with a smile.

Uncontrolled Explosion (3)



Elite · Alchemist · Ashford

Damage 4, +1 per reagent you hold, to all enemies. Consumes all reagents. 25% chance to burn yourself.

The incident report is clear: alchemical exhaustion, condolences to the guild, and a request to the domain to fund a new wall for the east wing.



Common Spear

UNIVERSAL · PIERCING

Four peoples, twelve wars, one design.



Sharp Knife

UNIVERSAL · CUTTING

For bread, rope and long conversations.



Griffin Crossbow

PHERION · THORNVAL · RANGED

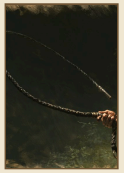
Crossbows were not invented to fight the Hilläru in flight, but they found their use.



Whaling Harpoon

YREI · OREYA · PIERCING

It never stopped being a weapon, however much it wanted to.



Phaenseld Overseer's Whip

HILLÄRU · SELD · CONTROL

He closed the book with his usual calm. He put out the candles. The sunset let them be seen from the window: on their knees, in chains, in the mud.



Curved Scimitar

ORTHAL · SÛRATH · CUTTING

"The quickest way to untie a knot is to cut it." Xérsh the Eyeless to his disciples, 1791 AR.

Several lines move a historical anecdote into the world: Augustus shouting for Varus's legions becomes a Hilläru lord shouting for his cavalry; the Gordian knot becomes desert teaching. AR and DR: before and after the Refoundation.

FOUR PEOPLES, FOUR WAYS OF SPEAKING

Four registers

Each culture of the world has its own register. These four pieces show the world speaking to the player through a letter, an object, a family's correspondence and a prayer.

ORTHAL · A LETTER FOUND AT THE EASTERN GUARD POST OF THE DRAKH'UL VERTEBRAE · UNDATED

Hälgur — the East pass was quiet this week. Eight caravans went up, six came down. Two of the ones that came down brought Khêmur from the Sûra oasis, and one of them said he knew your name. I did not ask him how. I gave him lodging and I gave him food, the way you taught me to do with those who pronounce our names well. At night he sang a song I do not know, in the desert tongue; I thought I recognized one word but I was probably wrong.

Our eldest daughter still asks after her father each time she comes up to the pass; the firstborn does not ask but tends the armor you left behind without anyone needing to tell him. I write this letter as I always write, knowing you will not read it. The stone of the East pass stands where it stood. So do I.

PHERION · PRIVATE CORRESPONDENCE, A MEMBER OF HOUSE ASHFORD TO HER COUSIN IN HOUSE SWYNN

Cousin, The Table approved the second quarter allocation with the customary fluency. The House does not figure among the principal signatories, as the current procedure requires. Hadral, the master alchemist, sent his greetings to my mother yesterday morning; my mother received them with the distance she always uses toward him and the tenderness she uses toward all.

The technical procedures continue their course. In other matters, little Santor seems to have left behind his fear of riding alone and already speaks of going to Kent to choose a horse; I told him I would ask you first. Give my regards to the Count, and to his wife, with the customary courtesy, and tell her, if she will allow it, that the blue handkerchief from the last visit was left at our house, and that I will send it with the next dove.

YREI · ITEM: TOOTHED-SPIRAL CONCH SHELL · FLAVOUR FOR AN ÁHNAREI MUSICAL PIECE

Polished over eleven sessions by the Onthárei family of the lesser atoll, tuned by Urilen Onthárei to the ancient pitch of the seventh cycle. The species the piece comes from has been extinct in the wild for three generations; this specimen has been preserved in the family collection since before the extinction. The house does not sell pieces of this species. The shell is lent, under conditions, for ceremonial music sessions in the Áhnareië atoll.

ORTHAL · FRAGMENT OF A JÚNEK PRAYER TO THE SHADOW, ADAPTED FOR DAILY USE IN THE LOWLANDS

The voice of the Father lies before the words. The Father is there when the words fail. The Father remains after the words end. We speak. He listens. He answers in His time, not in ours.

What the four share: none of them explains itself. The letter never says where Hälgur is; the conch never says why the species died; the cousin never says what the technical procedures are, though Ashford's end is in them; the prayer never says what the Father is.

TEAM OF TWO

The making

The game is built and playable: combat, equipment, events, missions, reputation, crafting, trade, the 3D run map and its settlements. It began as a 2D pixel-art card roguelite with fixed dungeons and grew into a semi-open 3D world. Still in progress: the enemy response system, the combat presentation and the narrative content of the later provinces. Everything in-game shown here was built on a 2018 laptop without a graphics card; it has never looked better, and it will never look worse.

Tomás Becerra	Creative direction and canon. World, factions and history. Game and systems design: archetypes, cards, items, economy, progression, events and missions. The in-world text, written by him or drafted with Claude and rewritten by him. Settlement layout and UI composition in the Godot editor.
Claude (Anthropic)	All code, in Godot 4 and GDScript. Technical production of the 3D run map and its tools. Design and writing proposals, which Tomás accepts, rewrites or discards. The English versions of the in-world texts, reviewed by Tomás.
Art and sound	Concept and card art generated with Midjourney under Tomás's direction. 3D settlements built from purchased low-poly asset packs. Music generated with Suno; sound effects from free libraries.

On tools

Kingdom of None was directed by one person and built with machines: a language model for the code and for drafts, an image model for the art, a music model for the score. None of them decides what the game is. Direction is the work: choosing, rejecting, rewriting, and knowing why. It is said here plainly because it is true, and because the work should be judged for what it is.

Tomás Becerra

THANKS

To Juan, Fran, Ginevra, Mini and Morcilla. I am one, but without them I am less.

EMAIL	tomas22becerra@gmail.com
BASED IN	Rome, Italy · open to relocation anywhere in Europe
LANGUAGES	Spanish (native) · English (C1) · Italian (B1) · German (A2)
BACKGROUND	Judicial and NGO writing, immersive installations, music teaching · international relations and law